



IN RAM'S NAME

The UPA Government's slip-up has given BJP an electoral issue that strikes at the heart of its votebank. As the Congress tries to recoup, Ambika Soni may well end up as the scapegoat.

■ By Priya Sahgal

When the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) begins chanting the name of Lord Ram with a desperate fervour, one conclusion can be safely drawn: elections are round the corner. Only this time, it is the Congress that has handed Ram to BJP on a platter. Also, the current controversy does not centre around a centuries-old religious monument, but on a modern navigation project which was inaugurated by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in July 2005.

Two years on, the Sethusamudram Shipping Channel Project has turned into a political tsunami and the latest cause of torment for the UPA Government. The project involves

dredging up of a ship canal at the southern-most tip of India to connect the east and the west coast through a continuous navigable sea route within the Indian territorial waters so that ships do not have to take the circuitous route around Sri Lanka. There are both strategic and economic advantages for India. However, the bone of contention is a 30-km-long chain of sand-capped rocky formation that lies between India and Sri Lanka. Known as the Adam's Bridge or the Ram Sethu, this prevents ships from travelling directly between the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal.

Equally contentious is the belief among sections of Hindus who feel this bridge was built by Lord Ram. The matter even reached the courts when Subramanian Swamy of the Janata

TRIGGER: Singh, Sonia, Karunanidhi and Baalu at Sethu inauguration

Party and other private parties filed writ petitions before the Madras High Court in May this year. Citing Hindu scriptures, Swamy asked for a stay on the project to prevent its demolition and instead wanted the Ram Sethu be declared as an "ancient monument". The case was transferred to the Supreme Court and on September 13, the Ministry of Culture headed by Ambika Soni, filed a counter affidavit questioning Swamy's contentions. One para in the 17-page affidavit was enough to raise the heckles of the Hindu brigade. The controversial para 20 says that the petitioners "have primarily relied on the contents of the Valmiki Ramayana, the Ramcharitmanas and other mythological texts which... cannot be said to be historical records to incontrovertibly prove the existence of the characters..."

For the saffron camp, this was as close to blasphemy as it could get. "In one stroke of its legal pen, the Government has sought to negate all that the Hindus consider sacred," thundered L.K. Advani, the leader of the Opposition, whose prayers for an